YIXING AUDIO GUIDE · PART V

Handcrafted Purple Clay Cup Workshop — English Audio Guide

Complete 7-Stop DIY Studio Script · 1.0s Sentence Pauses & 2.0s Paragraph Pauses · Total Duration: 6m 09s

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STOP 01 · 1:05 · GUZHENG & DIZI INTRO · cup_01_intro.mp3

Welcome to the Yixing Purple Clay Cup Workshop

Why Authentic Purple Clay Is Hand-Built by Beating Slabs Rather Than Spun on a Wheel & The Traditional Toolkit

Hello everyone, and welcome to our Yixing Purple Clay Workshop! Today, you are going to experience a 600-year-old intangible cultural heritage with your own hands by crafting your very own purple clay tea cup.

Unlike porcelain, which is spun on a fast potter's wheel, authentic Yixing purple clay is rich in natural quartz and iron minerals, giving it a sandy texture and unique "double-pore" breathability that keeps tea fragrant. Because of this special mineral structure, purple clay is never thrown on a wheel. Instead, artisans shape it entirely by hand—beating flat slabs of clay with a wooden mallet, wrapping the cylinder body, and bonding the pieces with fine clay paste. On the table in front of you, you'll find our traditional toolkit: the heavy wooden mallet, the compass circle cutter, a steel ruler and knife, the spinning turntable, a wooden paddle, and a damp smoothing cloth. Let's walk through the six simple steps to make your cup!

STOP 02 · 0:55 · GUZHENG GLISSANDO · cup_02_step1_round_disc.mp3

Step 1: Cut the Circular Clay Discs & Seal the Center Pinhole

5mm Sizing Template Disc, 3mm Base Disc & The Leak-Proof Pinhole Trick

Let's begin with Step One: cutting the circular clay discs and sealing the center pinhole. First, take a small block of purple clay and beat it evenly with the wooden mallet. We need two round discs of the exact same diameter: a thicker five-millimeter disc that acts as our inner sizing template, and a thinner three-millimeter disc that will become the bottom of your cup.

Place the clay slab in the center of your turntable. Hold the compass cutter steady, press the pivot needle into the center, and spin the wheel smoothly to slice a clean circle. Here is the most important tip of the day: right after you cut the bottom disc, while it is still lying flat on the wheel, take a tiny dab of clay and firmly fill in the center pinhole left by the compass needle! Smoothing that pinhole closed right now takes just a few seconds and guarantees that your finished cup will never leak from the bottom.

STOP 03 · 0:47 · BREEZE & CHIME · cup_03_step2_body_slab.mp3

Step 2: Beat the Rectangular Body Strip & Cut via the 3-Point Method

Uniform 3–3.5mm Wall Thickness & Marking Left, Center, and Right for a Parallel Cut

Now for Step Two: beating the rectangular body strip and cutting it with the three-point method. Take a longer block of clay and beat it outward from the center until you have a flat, even strip about three to three-and-a-half millimeters thick. That thickness gives the finished cup a balanced, refined feel in your hand.

Next, trim one long straight baseline along the bottom edge. To cut the top edge completely parallel, don’t just measure two points—measure your desired cup height at three points: left, center, and right. Line up your steel ruler across all three marks and slice straight through in one clean stroke. Using three points ensures your cup rim and base will be perfectly level.

STOP 04 · 0:52 · BAMBOO FLUTE MELODY · cup_04_step3_wrap_seam.mp3

Step 3: Wrap the Cylinder & Cut a 45-Degree Beveled Seam

Wrapping Around the 5mm Sizing Disc & Why a 45° Diagonal Joint Prevents Kiln Cracks

In Step Three, we wrap the cylinder and cut a 45-degree beveled seam. Place your five-millimeter sizing disc in the center of the turntable, stand your rectangular clay strip upright, and wrap it snugly all the way around the disc until the two ends overlap.

Where the two ends overlap, hold your knife at a 45-degree diagonal angle and slice through both layers at the same time. Why a 45-degree angle? Because a diagonal bevel creates 40 percent more contact surface than a straight cut, keeping the seam from cracking when the cup dries and fires in the kiln! Press the two beveled edges together, smooth the outer seam with your blade, and then support the outside wall with one hand while smoothing the inside seam. Once the cylinder is seamless, gently lift out the sizing disc.

STOP 05 · 0:43 · WATER DROPS & GUZHENG · cup_05_step4_attach_base.mp3

Step 4: Bevel the Rim, Apply Clay Paste & Attach the Base

45° Inner Rim Channel, Even Purple Clay Slip & Paddling the Pre-Sealed Base Tight

Moving on to Step Four: beveling the rim, applying clay paste, and attaching the base. With your hollow cylinder standing on the wheel, use your knife to trim a narrow 45-degree inward slope along the top rim. This creates a clean channel for bonding the base.

Next, use a small spatula to spread smooth purple clay paste evenly all the way around that beveled edge. Take the circular bottom plate you prepared and sealed in Step One, lay it flat on top of the cylinder, and press it down gently. Then, use your wooden paddle to tap firmly around the edge so the base bonds tightly to the wall, and spin the wheel to trim away any excess clay around the foot.

STOP 06 · 0:37 · BREEZE & CHIME · cup_06_step5_polish_rim.mp3

Step 5: Flip the Cup Upright & Burnish the Drinking Rim

Rounding Off the Knife-Cut Edge with a Damp Smoothing Cloth for a Silky Lip Feel

Now comes Step Five: flipping the cup upright and burnishing the drinking rim. Now that the bottom is sealed and trimmed, gently cup the cylinder with both hands and flip it right-side up in the center of the turntable.

Right now, the top rim was cut with a knife, so the edge is still flat and slightly sharp. Take your damp smoothing cloth, fold it gently over the lip of the cup, and spin the turntable steadily. In just a few turns, the sharp edge transforms into a smooth, rounded rim that feels silky and comfortable against your lips when sipping tea.

STOP 07 · 0:54 · GUZHENG & DIZI FINALE · cup_07_step6_marking_closing.mp3

Step 6: Add Your Personal Signature & Kiln Firing

Engraving Your Initials or Brushing Contrasting Slip Before the 1,180°C Firing

Finally, Step Six: adding your own personal signature! Your handleless purple clay cup now has a clean, classic silhouette, and it is time to make it unmistakably yours.

You can use a carving stylus to engrave your initials, the date, or a small motif onto the lower wall or the underside of the base. Or, if you prefer a painted look, dip a fine brush into contrasting light-colored clay slip to brush a minimalist design on the body. Please make sure to sign your initials clearly on the bottom of your cup so we can easily identify your piece when everyone’s cups come out of the 1,180-degree kiln!

Take your time, enjoy the meditative rhythm of working with Yixing purple clay, and have fun creating your one-of-a-kind souvenir!